

Siemens C60

Price: Rs 8,000 **A**

The Siemens C60 is a good performer; the voice clarity is good and reception is clear. At Rs 8,000 for the entire package including the camera, the C60 is sensibly priced. SMS junkies, keep away!

We liked the phone's looks, with its grey-silver outfit and dash of chrome. The colour panels are exchangeable. The keypad is traditional Siemens—small buttons, hard to press, and completely lacking in tactile feedback. The navigation keys, are quite cramped and add to the frustration when operating the phone: build quality is one area where a lot is left to be desired.



The 4K colour, 7-line display screen is nothing to write home about. When the phone is used indoors, the backlight is able to create the proper contrast for strain-free viewing. Outdoors, one can hardly read the screen. The icon-based menu structure is simple and intuitive.

The phone has a total of 350 phone book entries, 100 on the phone and 250 via the SIM card. Other good features include support for MMS, hands-free calling, and Java applications. There are 16 polyphonic ringtones and two games, although these can only be called mediocre.

There's an external camera attachment with a flash. It fits snugly into the data port at the bottom of the phone. Taking pictures takes its toll on the batteries, especially with the flash switched on.

The C60 offers tri-band compatibility. For data transfer, the C60 relies on GPRS. You might miss infrared functionality. The battery lasts about three days with normal use.

Nokia 6600

Price: Rs 26,069 **C**

The 6600 is definitely a phone to consider buying, especially if you are a Nokia fan and want a device with great flaunt value, decent features, excellent voice clarity and decent image capturing functionality—and also if you can afford the price of Rs 26,069. However, there are not many compelling reasons for existing Nokia 7650 or 3650 users to switch to a Nokia 6600.

Though the design may not appeal to you at first, it grows on you. The body is oval and features a dual-tone finish. In spite of being smaller than its predecessors, the 6600 feels bulky, and people with smaller hands may have an issue with single-handed operation. The keypad is standard Nokia. There's a five-directional joystick in the middle flanked by two soft-keys.

This tri-band GSM phone has a 176 x 208 active matrix 64K TFT display. The internal memory is 6 MB. There's also a memory card slot for additional user memory—a 32 MB MMC card is included in the package. The phone supports multiple entries per contact, custom ringtones and contacts can be assigned to groups. You can also assign thumbnail images to contacts which are displayed when scrolling through the contacts list or when the person calls you. The camera features 2X digital zoom and a self timer, and can shoot in standard, portrait and night modes. It can also capture video clips at 176 x 144 or 128 x 96 pixels, with or without audio. These can be played back on the installed RealOne Player.

Voice clarity is excellent and you will have no problems listening to a conversation even in a noisy environment. The perform-

ance of the hands-free speaker is also quite good, though not recommended in noisy conditions. The inbuilt polyphonic ringtones and more that you download play very nicely, though it may be difficult to hear the phone ringing if you are outdoors, even at maximum volume. If you want to use a number stored on your SIM card, you'll need to browse to the SIM directory. You cannot view your SIM and phone book contacts together. Even text messages stored on the SIM card are not displayed directly, which create a problem when you switch from the 6600 to another phone, as all messages you have received are stored in the phone memory.

Standard messaging features such as MMS, concatenated SMS, picture messages, SMS distribution lists, and predictive text input are supported. You can connect to other devices using Bluetooth or infrared, though there is no pop-port interface for wired connectivity. GPRS and HSCSD data transfer speeds can go up to 40.2 Kbps and 43.2 Kbps respectively.

An XHTML browser and a Wallet feature that can store passwords are also pre-installed. In terms of voice features, the device provides voice dialling, voice commands for applications, a voice recorder, and an integrated hands-free speaker. There is support for downloadable Java MIDP 2.0 applications. However, some of the features found in even entry level or mid-range Nokia phones are absent. Noticeable among these are an inbuilt stopwatch, repeat alarms, timed profiles, and automatic key-guard.

The 6600 comes with 4 themes preinstalled, and you can download others from WAP sites. Other applications available include notes, To Dos, a calendar with customisable views, and two games.

Using the keypad is not an issue at all, except if you have small hands. Text messaging should be a breeze for seasoned users, though the buttons on the lower part of the keypad lack depth.

Screen visibility reduces considerably in direct sunlight, but is usable. Still pictures captured using the camera are decent in good lighting conditions. In dim light, images turn out quite noisy as there is no flash. Another issue is that you need to hold the phone in position for a few seconds after clicking, otherwise you end up with blurry pictures. Video capture quality is not great, although it does the job. The audio captured with the video is fine, though. A negative point is the cap on length of clips that can be captured—just about 9 seconds, which is fine for sending via MMS.

As far as connectivity is concerned, we paired the device to a desktop PC using a USB Bluetooth adaptor and had no problems installing applications and transferring data. Even an infrared connection with the HandSpring Treo 180 was established without any hiccups. The included BL-5C battery offers a couple of days of life with normal use.



Conclusion

When it comes to smart features, nothing beats the Nokia 6600. Apart from great features, this was the only phone to come with an expandable 32 MB memory MMC card, and 6 MB inbuilt. Nokia's 7600, though, boasts of nearly the same features as the 6600, but completely lacks the slickness the latter offers in terms of usability. If you want an affordable smart phone, opt for the Siemens M55 from or LG's G5300i, which offers decent features at a significantly lower price.